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PREMIUM NOTES

SSC — English Language Notes

SSC Test Series — StuDy

High-yield facts, formulas and trap-radar — made for the real exam hall.

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SSC — English Language Notes

Error Spotting — Golden Rules

- Subject–verb agreement: the verb follows the REAL subject, not the nearest noun. 'The quality of the mangoes IS good.'
- 'One of the' + plural noun + SINGULAR verb: 'One of the boys HAS failed.'
- Each / Every / Either / Neither / None of (formal) → singular verb.
- Uncountable nouns (information, advice, furniture, luggage, news) never take 'a/an' or plural -s.
- 'Since' + point of time, 'for' + period of time — always with perfect tenses: 'He has been ill SINCE Monday / FOR two days.'
- Comparatives: 'senior/JUNIOR/superior TO', never 'than'. 'More' is not used with -er forms ('more better' is wrong).
- 'Hardly/Scarcely' pairs with 'when'; 'No sooner' pairs with 'than'.
- Collective nouns (team, committee, jury) — singular when acting as one unit.
- After 'It is time' use past tense: 'It is time we LEFT.'
- 'Lest' takes 'should': 'Walk carefully lest you SHOULD fall.'

Articles, Prepositions & Fixed Pairs

- Use 'an' before vowel SOUNDS (an hour, an honest man, an MLA) and 'a' before consonant sounds (a university, a European).
- 'The' before: rivers, oceans, mountain ranges, holy books, superlatives, unique things (the sun), newspapers, and 'the' + adjective for classes (the poor).
- No article before: languages, subjects, games, meals, and abstract nouns in general sense.
- Fixed pairs: good AT / bad AT, interested IN, afraid OF, depend ON, suffer FROM, married TO, different FROM, proud OF, fond OF.
- Since (point) vs For (duration) vs From (starting point, any tense).
- In time = before the deadline; On time = exactly at the scheduled time.

Active–Passive & Narration — Core Patterns

- Passive: object becomes subject + be-form by tense + V3 + by + agent. Tense NEVER changes in voice conversion.
- Imperative passive: 'Let the door BE shut.' Orders with 'please/kindly' → 'You are requested to…'
- Narration: reporting verb in past → tense shifts one step back (present→past, past→past perfect); today→that day, tomorrow→the next day, here→there.
- Universal truths and habits do NOT shift: 'He said that the earth REVOLVES round the sun.'
- Questions in narration: 'asked if/whether' for yes-no; wh-word retained for wh-questions; word order becomes assertive.

High-Frequency Idioms (PYQ grade)

- To bite the dust — to suffer defeat/fail. | To burn the midnight oil — to work/study late into the night.
- A blessing in disguise — a hidden benefit. | To cry over spilt milk — to waste time regretting the past.

- To let the cat out of the bag — to reveal a secret. | A red-letter day — an important/memorable day.
- To smell a rat — to suspect something wrong. | At the eleventh hour — at the last moment.
- To take with a grain of salt — to not take seriously. | A wild goose chase — a useless pursuit.
- To be in hot water — to be in trouble. | To turn a deaf ear — to ignore/refuse to listen.
- By leaps and bounds — very rapidly. | To beat about the bush — to speak indirectly.

One-Word Substitutions (PYQ grade)

- Remedy for all diseases — PANACEA. | One who can use both hands equally — AMBIDEXTROUS.
- One who speaks many languages — POLYGLOT (a linguist studies languages; a polyglot SPEAKS them).
- A speech made for the first time — MAIDEN speech. | One who never dies — IMMORTAL; one who grows never old — AGELESS distinctions matter.
- Government by the people — DEMOCRACY; by a king — MONARCHY; by the rich — PLUTOCRACY; by officials — BUREAUCRACY.
- A place where birds are kept — AVIARY; bees — APIARY; fish — AQUARIUM.
- One who looks at the bright side — OPTIMIST; dark side — PESSIMIST.
- Killing of one's own self — SUICIDE; of a king — REGICIDE; of a human — HOMICIDE.

Exam Strategy

- SSC English is a PRECISION game: the familiar-looking option is usually the trap. Match the EXACT definition, not a near one.
- In error spotting, read the sentence in parts A-B-C and check agreement FIRST — it is the most tested error.
- For PQRS, find the opening sentence (independent, introduces the subject), then mandatory pairs (pronoun links, 'this/that' links).

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